

Territorial Stigma and the Politics of Resistance in a Parisian *Banlieue*: La Courneuve and Beyond

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Abstract

Drawing on research carried out in the Parisian *banlieue* of La Courneuve, this article contributes to the sociological analysis of urban marginalisation in post-riot France. Beginning with a discussion of the broad relationship between society and space, drawing on Pierre Bourdieu's relational understanding of social space and how these complexities are inscribed in the urban, it moves on to consider how this relates to Lefebvre's production of space thesis. The main body of the article outlines some of the ways in which territorial stigmatisation is imposed and reproduced. Empirical material is treated here as 'diagnostic' of the symbolic domination that blights La Courneuve. Yet this material is also illuminative of the irregular and scattered forms that resistance to territorial stigma takes. It is suggested that the complex relationship between social and physical space is expressed through the construction of symbolic geographies of domination/resistance and negotiated through intricate 'entanglements of power'.

Quand le quartier fait même peur à la peste [When the 'hood can scare even the plague away] (in 'Qui ça étonne encore', La Rumeur, 2007)¹

Introduction

In May 2009, the communist mayor of La Courneuve, a *banlieue* situated on the north-eastern periphery of Paris, in the

Seine-Saint-Denis district, lodged a formal complaint of "*discrimination territoriale*" to the HALDE (Haute Autorité de Lutte contre les Discriminations et pour l'Égalité), the national body for anti-discrimination and equality. It was the first time this agency had received a 'collective' complaint from a city council. In addition to denouncing local failures and deficiencies in the spheres of

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education, housing and employment, the mayor addressed the stigma attached to La Courneuve, in particular the shame affixed to the notorious Cité des 4000 (alternatively the 'Quatre Mille' or simply 'Les 4000'), a disgrace consecrated in an enduring *imaginaire institué* (Castoriadis, 1975/1987) that associates France's urban periphery with the 'failures of integration' while also constructing them as *zones de non-droit* (no-go areas).

This social, symbolic and discursive landscape constituted around the French *banlieues* gained prominence in the dramatic context provided by the 2005 riots (*émeutes*), described by Murray (2006, p. 26) as "France's Hurricane Katrina". While Hurricane Katrina revealed the materiality of racial exclusion and the extent of the intimate link between socioeconomic marginalisation and the deep-rooted racialised uneven urban geography of the US (McKittrick and Woods, 2007), the 2005 uprising across France was seen as symptomatic of an acute societal crisis characterised by the exclusion of a large section of its multiethnic population from the 'Republican project' (*le projet républicain*). This social and spatial exclusion has worsened due to decades of state authoritarianism prioritising law and order (*securité*) over long-term socioeconomic and urban regeneration (see Autain *et al.*, 2006; Dikeç, 2007) in addition to a 'territorial stigmatisation' that is now "the single most protrusive feature of the lived experience of those entrapped in these sulfurous zones" (Wacquant, 2008a, p. 169).

It is the diffuse, rather than monolithic, sources of territorial stigmatisation and the myriad responses of residents to this spatial but also symbolic stigma that is the main concern of this article. La Courneuve—and more especially the Cité des 4000, one of the infamous *grands ensembles* of mass housing built at the beginning of the 1960s (see Power, 1993, p. 44) is perhaps the

most stigmatised Parisian *banlieue*.² During the post-war period, French cities, and especially Paris, struggled to meet the housing demands of a rapidly rising workforce. The housing crisis was so acute that much of the city's north-eastern periphery was comprised of *bidonvilles* (or shantytowns) built by Algerian, Portuguese and Spanish immigrants. Pressure on housing in Paris was further exacerbated by the arrival of around a million *pieds noirs*³ in 1962, who were housed in *cités* such as les 4000 in La Courneuve, which became a *zone à urbaniser en priorité* (ZUP), an 'area to be urbanised quickly'. The derogated status of La Courneuve, a product of the accumulation of negative representations (associating crime, *insécurité*, violence and immigration) was reinforced by Nicolas Sarkozy's visit to the *cité* on 20 June 2005⁴ when he vowed to '*nettoyer les cités aux Kärcher*',⁵ meaning that he would 'clean out' the housing projects, removing their '*racaille*' ('scum').

Drawing on primary qualitative data collected in La Courneuve during 2008,⁶ we explore how residents of La Courneuve, acutely aware of how they are perceived by the wider public, the media and politicians, negotiate the grammars of marginalisation associated with their *banlieue*, how they live with the effects of territorial stigma. In other words, we wish to examine the politics of domination and resistance, which, as Lapeyronnie (2008) shows in his seminal analysis of the *banlieue* experience, lies within the tension between internal self-perception and external images. While, like Lapeyronnie, we are interested in the various (and often ambivalent) ways in which *banlieue* residents make sense of their existence—opposing their vision of 'normality' with the 'exceptionalising' effects of the stigma—our objective is also to provide an analysis of mechanics involved in the production of space with particular

reference to how injustice is produced and reproduced (and challenged) through engagement with concrete and more symbolic forms of spatiality (see Lefebvre, 1991; Dikeç, 2001). Our discussion of Lefebvre and Bourdieu's views, on the production of the spatial (and relational) structuration of power, will occupy an important place in this analysis. However, we also want to acknowledge the lack of clarity in concrete instances of domination/resistance dynamics and spatial structurings of power. In our view, the existence, extent and diffuse nature of symbolic derogation become apparent in the *diagnostic* discursive practices of residents. Such counter-narratives "tell us about forms of power and how people are caught up in them" (Abu-Lughod, 1990, p. 42). This method is as much attuned to the mechanics of domination as tactics of resistance and is hesitant to draw clear distinctions between the two, preferring to recognise how power works through a subject's own sense of agency (see Bourdieu, 1990; Cresswell, 2000). It is hoped that this article will contribute to the analysis of urban marginalisation, first by outlining some of the ways that the territorial stigmatisation of a Parisian *banlieue* is imposed and reproduced and, secondly, by placing residents' responses to this stigma within a grounded discussion of relations of domination/resistance. Underpinning these aims is a clear concern with extending what Lefebvre (1996) calls the 'right to the city', an "imaginative opening ... and challenge to the current [urban] structure that points towards a new politics" (Purcell, 2003, p. 565).

The first section demonstrates how Bourdieu's relational understanding of social space enhances an understanding of the production of space with particular reference to how injustice is produced, reproduced and challenged through urban space (see Lefebvre, 1991; Dikeç, 2001). Next, the

stigma attached to the Cité des 4000 is considered in detail. The paper moves on to consider the attempts of residents to evade, challenge or live with territorial stigma. Finally the sociological and geographical impacts of symbolic domination and practices of resistance are analysed.

'Effets de Lieu'?

In an article somewhat neglected within urban studies, Pierre Bourdieu (1999) lays the foundations for a rigorous analysis of the relations between the structures of social and physical space, suggesting that the structures of social space are, in a blurred form, *inscribed* in physical space.⁷ In this way, inhabited or appropriated space functions as a "spontaneous symbolization of social space" (Bourdieu, 1999, p. 124) and this is what provides places with their social distinctions.⁸ The urban is therefore a *reification* of social space (Bourdieu, 1998, p. 120). Yet although social space is inscribed in spatial structures, the apparent straightforwardness of this 'reflection' is complicated by Bourdieu's dynamic vision of the arrangement of social space itself, which is shaped by the uneven distribution and combination of different kinds of capital (economic, cultural, social or symbolic) among (interdependent) 'agents'. To understand social space, then, is not to acknowledge a set of rigid class distinctions but, rather, to accept the principle of a *relational* understanding of the social world, based upon *difference* (Bourdieu, 1998, p. 31). The upshot is that urban space is as contradictory, fragmented and fluid as the contests played out in the manifold, overlapping fields of social space.

While space is dominated by appropriating the rare goods that are distributed there, not all spaces are dominated through the possession of economic capital. Symbolic, cultural or even political capital may be

needed to access and appropriate space and in most cases domination is achieved through the combination of several forms of capital. Yet, for Bourdieu, even when a space is dominated, the struggle for dominance within that space continues, creating contradictory social positions between ‘domination’ and ‘resistance’ for agents operating across various scales of the relational social space—like, for instance the communist mayor of La Courneuve (*dominant* locally, but in a *dominated* position within the wider regional and national political field). The domination of urban space is, then, the vexed outcome of (unequal and on-going) struggles within a myriad of urban-related social fields (architectural design, housing market, resource allocation, community politics, etc.). Domination is not a simple action exercised by a set of agents—such as ‘the dominant class’—who are invested with powers of coercion. Rather, it is the indirect effect of a complex set of actions and of intersecting constraints. As changes of position in social space (in relation to the ‘conversion rates’ between capital) are reflected in the urban, it is possible to see how *spaces* of domination/resistance are always in a process of *becoming*.

The symbolic meaning of places is integral to Bourdieu’s understanding of how social space is reproduced in and through the urban landscape. Relegated spaces such as La Courneuve enclose individuals and families already deprived of capital and exacerbate their exclusion by reducing the likelihood that they may gain access to capital in the future. Symbolic defamation “intensifies the experience of finitude: it chains one to a place” (Bourdieu, 1999, p. 127). Similarly, Lapeyronnie (2008, p. 143) argues that for residents negative images of their *banlieue* are perceived to be both the source *and* the consequence of urban segregation. This is an example of what Dikeç

(2001) calls the ‘injustice of spatiality’, the fact that

spatial dynamics not only aggravate but actually produce injustice through the stabilisation of social inequalities and problems, becoming a major reproducer of them (Dikeç, 2001, p. 1798).

Social space is granted permanence in urban space (p. 1793) not just in concrete forms such as housing, but also in the symbolic stigma and/or prestige that give rise to further injustice and ignominy. The social oppositions objectified in physical space are reproduced in thought and language, as categories of perception. In peripheral *banlieues* of Paris, a discursive denigration of place is

superimposed on the already existing stigmata traditionally associated with poverty ... or postcolonial immigrant status (Wacquant, 2008a, pp. 237–238).

Alternative representations of the *banlieues* are rarely heard in the wider public sphere, though this is not to say they do not exist. Indeed, as Lapeyronnie (2008) suggests, the *ghetto urbain* is not simply the product of structural forces: the *banlieue* space is above all a *contre-monde* defined by the discursive and social engagement of those who inhabit it, which, while internally differentiated, provides a ‘collective answer’ to a ‘series of collective constraints’ (Lapeyronnie, 2008, p. 27). As we shall see, residents of the ‘counter-world’ of the *banlieues* experience marginalisation but they are also *agents* of a symbolic condition that is both internalised and negotiated.

The Production of Space and the Right to the City

This ‘practical’ engagement of differently positioned agents within the multiple fields of social space and the inscription of this

reality in spatial structures can help us to understand the complexities of what Lefebvre (1991) calls the 'production of space'. For Lefebvre, production is implied in a broad sense, as a material, mental and lived process, and it is not only 'things' that are produced but also *oeuvres* (or artistic works) such as the city. Lefebvre asserts that all residents of the city, even the least powerful, are involved practically (to greater or lesser degrees) in the production of space. The crucial aspect is that, while some residents enjoy *all* the city has to offer, others are denied this right to the city; they are effectively alienated from the *oeuvre* they are active in producing.

It is necessary to rehearse briefly the three 'levels of determination' that Lefebvre (1991) views as integral to the production of space. The first is 'spatial practices' (or space as it is *perceived*). The notion of practice captures the moment of connectivity between objective and subjective states; it refers to people doing things. While the 'performance' of spatial practices can give the appearance of order or predictability, this does not imply that spatial practice is rational; rather

the spatial practice of a society secretes that society's space; it propounds and presupposes it ... it produces it slowly and surely as it masters and appropriates it (Lefebvre, 1991, p. 38).

Practice always involves 'overcoming' or 'going beyond' design or expectations; thereby it is critical to the reproduction of space. Lefebvre claims that

'modern' spatial practice might thus be defined—to take an extreme but significant case—by the daily life of a tenant in a government-subsidized high-rise housing project (Lefebvre, 1991, p. 38).

The second and most dominant element in any mode of production is 'representations

of space' (or space as it is *conceived*). This is space as conceptualised by professionals and technocrats such as planners, developers, architects, estate agents and others of a scientific bent. Representations of space are also the space of capital. Ideology, power and knowledge are embedded in representations of space, which find 'objective expression' in monuments and buildings built at the behest of the market/state.

The third concept in the triad is 'representational space' (or space as it is *lived*). Lived space is the space of the imaginary—the space of "subjects' not calculations" (Lefebvre, 1991, p. 362). It is also the productive realm that opposes the rationalistic conceptions of space purveyed by architects, planners and developers. It is this level into which *conceived space* increasingly intervenes in capitalist societies, encouraging urban nightmares rather than utopian dreams. Unsurprisingly, Lefebvre's three 'levels of determination' rarely result in a 'complete' space or in clear-cut relations of dominance/resistance. Each space is instead likely to reveal intricate "entanglements of power" comprised of "an amalgam of forces, practices, processes and relations" (Sharp *et al.*, 2000, p. 20).

Acknowledging the amount (and kinds) of capital possessed by individuals and groups is critical to understanding the level(s) of production to which they are likely/able to contribute—space as *perceived*, *conceived* or *lived*. Simply put, some individuals or groups have more influence over the production of cityspaces than others. In the *banlieues*, the deprived status of most residents means that their productive activities are usually (although not exclusively) limited to the *perceived* or *lived* realms that in technocratic, advanced capitalist societies are dominated or "set alongside those representations of space which ... interfere with them" (Lefebvre, 1991, p. 41). Residents of the *banlieues* do not have great amounts of capital to work with in their 'productive'

activities and their powers of appropriation are therefore relatively confined—they cannot afford to move to apartments in the centre of Paris; they possess neither the qualifications nor the prestige to be commissioned to redesign or rebuild their living spaces; nor are they likely to be, or have access to, reporters for major TV or press networks in order to challenge negative stereotypes of their *banlieue*. As Dikeç argues

The right to the city implies not only the participation of the urban citizen in urban social life but more importantly his or her active participation in the political life, management, and administration of the city (Dikeç, 2001, p. 1790).

It is at the level of the everyday that relations of dominance are lived, reproduced and contested (Lefebvre, 2000). The most striking aspect of interviews with residents of La Courneuve is their sense of injustice at the stigma they bear. Residents do not accept this imposition with passivity. They are active in ‘carrying’ the stigma, whilst simultaneously challenging or wrestling with its effects. It is easy to recognise that La Courneuve suffers from territorial stigma, but where this “blemish of place” (Wacquant, 2007, p. 67) comes from, how it differentially impacts upon the daily lives of residents and what they do in response requires careful analysis. In the next section, we explore how the stigma is expressed within and beyond the *banlieue* experience, in the dialectics of external representation and internal identification.

In and Out of La Courneuve: Diagnostics of Territorial Stigma

Almost all the Courneuvian interviewees deplored the ‘gap’ (“*fosse*”) between the

external representations of La Courneuve and the reality they experience. They also often stressed how territorial stigmatisation ‘follows’ them and ‘invades’ their social life outside the *quartier*. For instance, Mouna talked about how negative external perceptions of La Courneuve and especially les 4000, set her apart from colleagues and makes her ‘known’ in a way she has little control over

We are marginalised. At my workplace when I say I am from Les 4000, they say ‘oh la la’. I feel bad about it so I have to explain, ‘Look, I am employee like the others’. But I have said it, so it follows me (Mouna, 54).

The stigma attached to the Cité des 4000 is such that residents sense they are viewed as a ‘race apart’ by nearby Paris and the wider French public. Racism is redefined as directed not at a particular ethnicity or phenotype (i.e. ‘*noir*’, ‘*arabe*’, ‘*maghrébin*’, etc.) but to the social (and spatial) category of those who reside in the *banlieue*

I have never experienced racism in La Courneuve, but outside yes, and also when I say I am from La Courneuve, like in my work. When I am outside, they know I am from the Quatre Mille (Samadia, 53).

Yes, we often go to Paris. When they see a ‘*troupeau*’ [a ‘herd’ of youths], they are scared ... it’s normal. People from Paris, young and adults, they know we are coming from the *banlieue*! (Said, 15).

As Samadia and Said explain, it is when they venture *outside* that they are identified as symbols of absolute social, cultural and moral difference. Said is recognised as coming from the *banlieue* simply because he visits Paris with a group of friends and the ‘fear’ that this instils in Parisians is viewed by Said as ‘normal’. Yet, later in the

interview, Said revealed how the reputation of les 4000 (and more specifically the fear that it provokes in others) is also used to gain ‘respect’ from young people in other *banlieues*. Said trades his public disgrace for an ‘illegitimate’ form of symbolic capital with highly specified ‘returns’ that allows his group of friends to regain some forms of ‘representational’ power. However, the views of parents interviewed were different as they were very concerned at how La Courneuve’s stigma could lead to discrimination in employment, thus restricting access to legitimate forms of capital for the younger generations

But when the kids are looking for a job in Paris, and they say they are from La Courneuve, they don’t get anything ... There is discrimination towards the *banlieue*, that’s for sure! My daughter is a secretary but she applied for jobs in Paris and got rejected many times (Sarah, 53).

In the eyes of many Courneuvien, the media shoulder a great deal of responsibility for their territorial stigmatisation. Some explained how negative and sensationalist images of the *banlieues* (such as burning cars) help to boost TV ratings (“ça fait monter l’audimat”) because they conform to dominant representations. Similarly, Amadou, a retired teacher and chairman of a Malian community group, reflecting on a discussion with a journalist from *Le Monde*, pointed to the discrepancy between how young residents described their life in the *banlieue* and what is eventually reported

We had a journalist from *Le Monde*, she wrote really bad things about La Courneuve. We had a discussion with her and I also arranged for several young people of La Courneuve to be present. All that we had talked with her during an hour and a half, she didn’t write anything about it, because it didn’t fit with

what she wanted, it was horrible (Amadou, 62).

Symbolic denigration, as well as the representation in French public policy that the *banlieues* constitute “objects of intervention” (Dikeç, 2007, p. 21), legitimates and supports physical violence against residents. The police create a routinised climate of tension through the daily harassments and *contrôle au faciès* (identity checks singling out minority youth).⁹ This was recurrent in the testimonies of many youth who voiced a powerful feeling of humiliation—or the Arabic term *hagra* (Mucchielli and Le Goaziou, 2006; see also Mucchielli, 2009)

They stop and search us for nothing. We walk on the street, they know us, they know everything about us, it’s really to piss us off [*pour nous faire chier*]. All the time, all the time, they search us, they know us, they know our names. We don’t have a good relationship with them (Mohammed, 17).

The policemen would come to us and insult us, for nothing. Every time they stop and search us [*un contrôle*], like ‘go back to your country’, things like that (Said, 15).

What Lapeyronnie (2009, p. 23) calls the “permanent duel” between youth and the police has come to occupy a symbolic centrality in *banlieue* popular culture. Films such as *La Haine*, *L’Esquive* or *Ma 6-T va crack-er*, all contain scenes of tense or violent confrontation between police and youth. French hip-hop groups from the 1990s (NTM, Assassin, Ministère Amer) and more recently (Sniper, La Rumeur, Lunatic) have also addressed the role played by the police in the symbolic and physical domination of *banlieue* youth—sometimes describing police methods as shaped by a “neo-colonial habitus” (La Rumeur).

It was not only the relationship with the police that was seen as a reflection of the state's categorisation of the *banlieues* as a denigrated space. For Mouna, even the daily experience of the RER, the suburban train linking Paris to its *banlieues*, reflected the ways in which Courneuvien are perceived and treated

They don't even give us the time to get off the RER. 'Aubervilliers-La Courneuve, come on, get out! Get out!' [*allez, dégagez!*]. They treat us like dogs and all this because we live in La Courneuve. But when the RER stops at La Plaine de France, the next stop, it goes slowly. You'll find station managers; there is a clear difference! They do that because they don't like us! (Mouna, 54).

It is interesting to consider whom Mouna referred to when she stated that "*they* don't like us". It is likely that she implies 'the state' (broadly conceived) or perhaps the city as an administrative body. She gives a sense that her example is not isolated, but constitutive of denigration occurring across a variety of fields bureaucratically controlled by the state. Residents are aware that their symbolic domination does not emanate from a single source—rather, it seems that *everybody* is against them.

Residents complain about a gap between the reality of life in Cité des 4000 and how the media and politicians represent their abode. This sense of injustice is not concerned solely with the symbolic since they perceive the stigma attached to La Courneuve as intertwined with discriminatory practices, such as on-going ill treatment by employers, colleagues, service providers and of course the police. The stigma is therefore 'enforced' and reproduced by a variety of sources (from 'above' and 'below') resulting in diffuse effects that do not impact upon all residents equally.

Counter-narratives and Urban Interventions

Foucault (2003, p. 139) describes the relationship between power and resistance as "agonistic", an affiliation of incitement and struggle, a situation of "permanent provocation". In this section, a variety of attempts at 'resistance' to territorial stigma or dominant representations of *banlieue* space are discussed. This analysis distinguishes heuristically between 'counter-narratives', which consist primarily of representational forms of escape, and 'urban interventions' that are based more around spatial practices.¹⁰

Counter-narratives?

As de Certeau (1994) suggests, the city is never univocal. Discursive struggles over representation are as fiercely fought and as fundamental to the activities of place construction as bricks and mortar (Harvey, 1996, p. 322). Territorial stigma incites residents to enter a representational space, or field, where they encounter dominant technocratic and media representations of space and, critically, envisage a transformed space. Bourdieu (1998, p. 78) likens this investment to a social libido, an impulse transformed into a socially constituted interest. Similarly, Lefebvre (1991) understands the representational space of dominated groups to be 'alive' in that it resists rules of consistency and cohesion. This vigour is evident in how residents describe the continuous struggle ("*un long combat*") to project an affirmative place-image and talked about the intense 'labour' required to create a tactical reversal of the stigma. In a sense, residents of La Courneuve feel impelled to construct an alternative place-image, to enter a representational realm shaped by the dominant stigma thereby demonstrating how relations of domination

imply and activate forms of negotiation or even 'resistance' (Bourdieu, 1992, p. 80).

Some take a different tack. Mouna, for instance, adopts almost a tactical refusal, asserting that, 'despite everything', *we* like La Courneuve and ultimately that is all that matters

I feel Courneuvien—it's the most important identity for me. We like La Courneuve despite all the attacks against us, despite the stigma, despite everything (Mouna, 54).

Mouna's approach may be considered passive in the sense that she does not appear willing to rise to the discursive challenge that the stigma poses, yet her 'introspection' results in a certain liberation. Mouna displays an awareness of a division between 'them' (the dominant) and 'us' (the oppressed, a 'race apart'), but moves beyond this binary to evoke a 'third' space that is simply Courneuvien. This 'Courneuvien identity' is located in the blind spots of the dominant classification; it is not a form of opposition as such, but an assertion of the right to be *other*. It is something only residents can *know*, a performance only they can truly *inhabit*.

Residents like Mouna do not 'reverse' the racialisation and/or ethnicisation of their collective relegation, but instead take comfort in a 'quiet' cosmopolitanism, a representational imagining of a Courneuvian identity embedded in a place that contains '80 different communities', where 'one travels without moving'. The cosmopolitan and diasporic composition of La Courneuve is thus a source of strength for many. As a result, the everyday experience of cultural *mixité* was viewed positively insofar as the heterogeneity and fluidity of the community are juxtaposed with the homogenising effect of the stigma. This is an expression of the 'right to difference' (rather than particularity), referring to the "right not to be

classified forcibly into categories which have been determined by the necessarily homogenising powers" (Lefebvre, 1976; quoted in Dikeç, 2001, p. 1790)

I am everything at once [*tout en même temps*]!
There's not one identity more important ...
Everything is together—as long as you respect me (Said, 15).

This is especially relevant in the hegemonic and rigid context of the French Republican nationhood, which tends to mute and gloss over the politics of difference and the multicultural/intercultural dimensions of contemporary post-colonial French society (Amirault and Simon, 2006; Boubeker, 2009; Gondola, 2009; Murray, 2006).

Residents are never completely victims of *indifference*, since the cultural diversity of the Cité des 4000 offers plenty of escape routes.¹¹ Even when it appears we are trapped in space, "we can never ever be purely 'local' beings" (Harvey, 1996, p. 353). Some residents are so proud of the diverse cultural life in the Cité des 4000 that they counter-intuitively contrast their *banlieue* with Paris, sometimes described as 'too quiet' ("*trop calme*") in comparison with the cosmopolitan sociability of La Courneuve. Others even challenged the symbolic and spatial marginalisation of the *banlieue* by suggesting that it is in fact Paris, with its increasing class and cultural homogeneity, which was 'isolated' (*isolé*). However, it is rare for this discrete Courneuvien identity to be expressed or achieve recognition beyond the *cité* or the pages of the mayor's free local newspaper that is alone in reporting positively on the diverse cultural life of La Courneuve.

Residents, therefore, do not unquestioningly accept the denigration of their *banlieue*. They seek to extricate themselves, often temporarily, from what they recognise as an unfair imposition, a "dispossession of

their self-perceptions” (Lapeyronnie, 2008, p. 22). Although they stress the effort and time that it would take to elude the territorial stigma, they are almost incited to oppose its legitimacy and to construct counter-narratives of space. Most noticeably many residents refuse the *indifference* of territorial stigma and take solace in the cultural diversity of the Cité des 4000. All residents are implicated, albeit through the dominated representational sphere in the production of a transformed space.

Urban Interventions I: The 2005 Riots

I don't think there was another solution, we are fed up of speaking [*y en a marre de parler, parler*]. Everyone talks, talks, talks but when we talk there's no point. We needed to act (Said, 15, talking about the 2005 riots).

The most obvious place to start regarding urban interventions (denoting a practical rather than representational sphere) is the 2005 riots. Yet here is a paradox. The media chose La Courneuve as a base for their reports, viewing it as the ‘natural’ place to station their rolling news broadcasts, even though rioting was less pronounced in comparison with neighbouring *cités* at Clichy-sous-Bois or Sarcelles. In fact, there were no reports of disturbances in La Courneuve until ‘day three’ of the rioting (Mucchielli and Le Goaziou, 2006). The reason given for the lack of activity in the early stages was not a lack of willingness on the part of residents, but the huge police presence that had congregated in the *cit  * in anticipation of rioting

There was a climate of tension, but more because of seeing all the police vans, CRS [riot police] vans. Helicopters were also watching. I think that was more threatening [*angoissant*] than what was really happening. Of course,

cars were burning, but I was in a state of war. I was stressed, with all the helicopters, the police. It was too much. I have experienced more what was *around* the riots, than the riots themselves (Micheline, 49).

The ‘nesting’ of emergency riot police squads inside sensitive zones of the urban periphery has been documented elsewhere (Wacquant, 2008b, p. 22). As Micheline suggests, whilst residents did not witness widespread youth revolt, they did experience the invasion and occupation of La Courneuve by the CRS. They describe this incursion by the state as a frightening episode that exceeded usual levels of insecurity on the estate. The territorial stigma is such that violent disorder was almost *summoned* into existence.

Perhaps this explains the intergenerational understanding for the belated disorder that did occur in the Cité des 4000. Some interviewees argue that the actions of young rioters were born out of respect for themselves and their *cit  *, a ‘love for life’ according to one resident, perhaps even a ‘cry and demand’ for the right to the city (Lefebvre 1996, p. 158).¹² This echoes the views of many scholars who have stressed how *banlieue* youth, who in their great majority had no delinquent past, entered the public arena during the riots to stress the extent of their marginalisation and to express a collective claim for social existence—a sort of “repoliticisation from below”, as coined by Kokoreff (2006, p. 530). Building on Hobsbawm’s (1959) idea of ‘primitive rebellion’, Lapeyronnie argues that the rioters’ modes of action suggest an oscillation

between the moral affirmation of their right to exist, their right to live, and the use of destructive but rational violence from which they hope to gain entry to or acknowledgment from the system (Lapeyronnie, 2009, p. 43).

In this sense, rioters set about the task of claiming a new space of inhabitability by destroying the existing space that denied them this right.

However, much has also been said about the *absence* of political meaning of the 2005 riots. Some sections of the mainstream press, ‘media intellectuals’ and the right-wing government, predictably discussed the ‘nihilist’ violence and the necessary restoration of the ‘authority of the state’ whilst pointing to the urban malaise of ‘integration’ (Mauger, 2006). This hegemonic *doxa*¹³ confirmed the worst aspects of the prejudice held against the *banlieue*—that they are degraded spaces of racialised disorder requiring a penal response (Wacquant, 2008b). Ultimately, those with the authority to do so ascribed the meaning of the riots, while ownership of the violence was snatched from residents. Yet the political meaning of the riots *was* also discussed in a controversial and popular book on the politics of contemporary insurrection written anonymously by the ‘Invisible Committee’ (IC) (2009) where it is argued that what made the riots distinctive is that the youth involved did not answer to anyone (their elders, political organisations or associations) and that their actions could not easily be ‘read’—thereby defying political appropriation. For the IC, the ‘wordless destruction’ of the riots inscribed a denial of the political (there were no explicit ‘claims’ for better housing, education, etc.), which in paradox makes the riots *acutely* political. Yet the ‘targets’ of rioters perhaps did reveal a syntax that pointed to the diffuse nature of their perceived antagonists. The fact that hundreds of secondary schools were targeted by young rioters may be seen as a symbolic reaction, a reflection of the role that schools and the education system play in producing and reproducing territorial stigma, class and ethnic prejudice (Ott, 2006; Lapeyronnie, 2009).

Urban Interventions II: The Poetics of Place

We explore here other forms of urban intervention undertaken by residents of La Courneuve which play with the aesthetics and poetics of place. Just as symbolic domination is inflicted upon the *banlieue* from many sources, contestation or objection also takes part in diffuse fields—including the artistic and its various sub-fields. The stationing of fifty-year-old Texan artist Monte in an old windmill in the heart of the Cité des 4000 is, in itself, an example of how the expectations of place are easily confounded. As well as converting the upstairs of the mill into a flat 15 years ago, Monte rents studios in the mill to other artists and heads an organisation called FACE (French Association for Creative Exchange) with the support of La Courneuve’s communist mayor. Monte was drawn to La Courneuve because the image of the place was so negative. He asks “where shine better than in the dark?” (FACE, 2009). Monte’s projects, which he refers to as “social sculptures”¹⁴ are first and foremost concerned with *rupture*

Les Quatre Mille is a symbol in France. *Les Quatre Mille* represents an image about the worst of the *banlieue*. We want to use this ‘bad boy’ image ... it’s there in the dark that it’s easier to shine, to create ruptures, breaks with normality, you just need to think about contrasts (Monte, FACE, 2009).

Monte uses artistic interventions to force a rupture in the stigma and fill the emergent void with creativity from local residents. This energy, which Monte maintains is present ‘but hidden away’, is referred to as an *abondance*—literally an ‘abundance’ of vitality that the undifferentiated shame of territorial stigma stifles. The notion of *abondance* resonates with Lefebvre’s (1991) notion of

representational spaces which provide a sphere for “the clandestine or underground side of social life” (p. 33) to flourish.

FACE organise a number of projects or interventions that induce a break with normality and are also active in the production of a transformed *banlieue* space. These include an initiative called “*lieu-non-lieu: micro-urbanisme à La Courneuve*” which involves local youth meeting students from the prestigious ESA (Ecole Spéciale d’Architecture). For Monte, the implausibility of this exchange was as important as any artistic outcomes. Young residents were asked to adopt a forgotten corner of the *cit  * and appropriate the space for their own uses, representing an attempt to establish a priority for the use value of urban space over the exchange value of capitalists or the symbolic value of the state (see also Purcell 2003). Monte hoped that *urbanistes* from the architecture school would learn how people value space even in a ‘worthless’ environment. A further example of social sculpture is a summer concert organised by FACE in September 2008. The concert, staged under a concrete mushroom in an underused communal space positioned between a football court and shopping precinct, juxtaposed a baroque choir from Paris with local hip-hop artists. The event ended convivially with artists, singers, residents and teenage soccer players mixing at a Texan barbeque prepared by Monte’s parents. Yet despite Monte’s interest in using art to produce a new identity for La Courneuve, he is aware that this endeavour is subject to many pitfalls—especially the danger of reproducing territorial stigma

The paradox of La Courneuve is that we cannot say anything good because it means you are being ‘angelic’, nor can we say anything bad because you are therefore falling into the stereotype (FACE, 2009).

The problem, that Monte recognises, is that resistance can never gain a position of exteriority in relation to power (Foucault 1979, p. 95).

In contrast with Monte’s co-ordinated interventions, Jean, 60, the chairman of ‘La Courneuve Fleurie’ intercedes almost coincidentally to challenge the stigma of La Courneuve. If flowers have aesthetic and sensorial properties, they can also acquire, in certain circumstances, the potential to oppose dominant representations of space. Jean reflected upon how the activities of his community group confront the dominant view of *la banlieue* as a super-urban, bleak and monotonous space

We take part in international dahlia contests. We won a first prize in Tours. So we are trying to get out of La Courneuve, we are trying to give another image of La Courneuve. Because when we talked about La Courneuve in Tours, for example, people would say straight away: ‘La Courneuve, Les Quatre Mille!’ and all this ... Now, when we go to Tours, it’s more: ‘La Courneuve, the dahlias!’. So in that sense it has changed! (Jean, 60).

Jean is almost corralled into resistance by the response to his flowers and the incongruous fact they were grown in La Courneuve. Even in the obscure field of dahlia contests, he cannot escape the stigma associated with his *banlieue*—Jean discovers that there is no innocent position. Yet whilst Jean’s association achieves recognition within the field of flower contests and confounds the expectations of place, he is critical of how dominant fields such as the mass media focus exclusively on the *doxic*

The media, I will tell you—when there is something good happening they don’t talk about it. But when it’s bad they do. Like us, we win first prizes internationally, but they

don't talk about us. But a car burns down in Les Quatre Mille, the day after it's in the news (Jean, 60).

Rather than glibly celebrating 'resistance' or drawing overpessimistic conclusions about the impact of place stigma (although some pessimism may be warranted), it is necessary to direct attention rather towards what we view as two ambiguities of domination/resistance. The first aspect of ambiguity is the acknowledgement that domination and resistance imply the existence of each other, yet are not reducible to one another. Some activities or discourses may appear 'resistant' to a set of constraints, but this does not exhaust their sociological or phenomenological meaning (see Cohen and Taylor, 1992). For example, the evocation of a Courneuvien identity, participation in riots or the staging of artistic ruptures can be read as 'acts of resistance', yet these subjective or practical 'responses' to an unjust stigma also possess a practical logic of their own, relating to alternative fields of activity defined by various degrees of autonomy from the set of relations under scholastic scrutiny here (i.e. friendship, the on-going 'games' played between police and youth, the artistic field). On the other hand, when people such as Jean the florist engage in fields such as international dahlia contests, they may be surprised when others interpret their activities in relation to a symbolic field they had not realised they were invested in. In this sense, resistance often occurs while people are busy doing other things. This of course is why Bourdieu (1998) questions whether the *disinterested* act is ever possible. The second point of ambiguity concerns the familiar issue of reproduction—that domination may be "reproduced through the multitude of individual acts that conform to a pre-given mode of power" (Cresswell, 2000, p. 261). As Mitchell (1990) explains, practices of 'resistance' are always

conditioned by hegemony, since their logics accept, at least in part, existing social, cultural, economic and geographical structures. It is for this reason that Ferrell (2001, p. 177) views all forms of praxis and 'resistance' as flawed because they are necessarily caught within a web of contradictions. It is not the aim of this article to judge just *how* flawed counter-narratives or urban interventions are, but to stress how resistance can never proceed from a position 'beyond' the territorial stigma of La Courneuve. All the examples of resistance reviewed here (as a result of their articulation by our respondents) reproduce the territorial stigma of La Courneuve—they cannot do otherwise—and yet they all contribute, however, modestly, to the production of a different kind of *banlieue* space. Domination/resistance are best not viewed as a dualist relation. They are more helpfully conceived as a struggle that is always in the process of producing something *other*—a transformed space of social relations and a modified (for better or worse) urban space.

Conclusion: Territorial Stigma and Symbolic Capital

The stigma experienced by residents of La Courneuve is part of a condition of 'advanced marginality' (Wacquant, 2008a) whereby the *banlieues* are

physically [and] symbolically held at a distance from goods [and legitimate forms of capital] that are the rarest socially (Bourdieu, 1999, p. 127).

This 'injustice of spatiality' (Dikeç, 2001) impels residents to 'resist' in ways that reproduce (to various degrees) their collective defamation. The paradox though is that the extreme social and spatial marginalisation of the *cité* enriches this space with

rare forms of symbolic, cultural and political capital that those already sufficiently endowed with capital can appropriate to enhance further their social position. This resonates with how often the 'profits' of many acts of resistance are unable to be accessed by their 'producers' since they do not meet the conditions of entry to legitimate fields. Rather, the capital from their endeavours is appropriated and held by agents invested in legitimate fields such as the media, bureaucratic, artistic or academic. For instance, whilst the activities of artists 'in residence' serve many positive social functions, it should not be forgotten that artistic works, especially those that utilise the negative symbolic capital of *jeunes de banlieue*, are valued highly in the international cultural and liberal arts field. The world-wide success of Mathieu Kassovitz's (1995) film *La Haine*, which Vincendeau (2005, p. 25) suggests merely recycles a deeply ingrained representation of the *banlieues*, is a case in point. This situation, where the rare veracity of the stigma heaped upon La Courneuve bequeaths the Cité des 4000 with a wealth of symbolic capital that entraps residents but makes the space 'rich' for the powerful, is very much in line with how Bourdieu (1999, p. 124) understands the "power over space that comes from possessing various kinds of capital". Whilst residents gain many phenomenological benefits from attempts to escape an oppressive reality (Cohen and Taylor, 1992), this exploitative relation is no secret to residents. It is a source of resentment, an apt illustration of the disjuncture experienced by marginalised groups between 'speaking' and being 'spoken for' (Spivak, 1988).

This paper provides an examination not only of the territorial stigma attached to La Courneuve, but also of the ways in which residents attempt to evade or live with this disgrace. This is achieved by connecting

geographies of domination/resistance with the complex relationship between social and physical space, a liaison—or rather, a *process* that Lefebvre (1991) refers to as the production of space. The confinement of residents to dominated levels of determination in the production process—the lived and perceived (a relegation resulting from a lack of capital/s)—reveals why residents of the *banlieue* are denied full participation in the production of the *oeuvre*. Relations of domination/resistance are an intrinsic component of the production of space at each level of determination; each level is contested within a multiplicity of related, specialised fields. For example, even at a very local level, in the representational realm, the meanings of different buildings in the *cité* are contested. Whereas the estate appears from the outside as a monolithic ensemble, inhabitants describe it as a set of 'micro territories' differentiated according to how 'hot' (volatile or dangerous) they are perceived to be

There are different *quartiers*. Balzac is 'hot' [*c'est chaud*] but I am not from there, but I know it's rough. Everyone knows Balzac. Rateau—it's nice and calm [*tranquille, sympa*]. The mayor of La Courneuve lives there! (Mohammed, 17).

The process whereby social space is "roughly superimposed" (Bourdieu 1999, p. 125) upon physical space results in intricate entanglements of power (Sharp *et al.*, 2000). While La Courneuve may be accurately described as suffering from an acute territorial stigma linked to the multiple structurations of advanced marginality and while this is actually imposed, carried and resisted in diffuse ways, our objective was also to show that there is no simple dualist relation between domination and resistance. This diagnostic account of the irregular and scattered forms that resistance takes (through

counter-narratives and interventions) is illuminative of the mechanisms of an extraordinary symbolic domination perceived by residents of La Courneuve.

Notes

1. La Rumeur are a 'conscious hip-hop' group. Themes covered in their songs include immigration, racism and police brutalities, but also neo-colonisation and the legacy of the Algerian war.
2. The space of the Cité des 4000 comprises a mix of high-rise and low-rise apartment blocks in addition to football and basketball courts, a shopping precinct and cultural centre. It is also divided by a complex 'ring road' system that creates the north (Quatre Mille Nord) and south (Quatre Mille Sud) regions.
3. 'Black feet', French settlers from Algeria.
4. Sarkozy was Interior Minister at the time.
5. A *Kärcher* is the brand name for an industrial high-pressure water hose, the kind which is used to clean accumulated dirt and grime from a car, pavement or building.
6. Twenty-one semi-structured interviews were conducted with ordinary *Courneuvien*s, youth workers, community activists, artists and council officials.
7. Lefebvre (1991, p. 55) similarly explains how the class struggle is 'inscribed in space'.
8. This formulation builds upon Bourdieu's (1977) classic study of how the organisation of Kabyle society is translated into the symbolic micro geography of the Kabyle household.
9. See also *Libération*, 'Le contrôle au faciès démontré par A + B', 30 June 2009.
10. The distinction made between 'representational' and 'practical' spheres is used heuristically—as abstractions—for organisational purposes. The authors agree, following Lefebvre (1991), that, in concrete historical examples, these spheres are integrated and also conditioned by dominant 'representations of space'. The result—urban space—is a *totality* of human efforts.
11. This is supported by Avery (1987, pp. 21–22) who finds in Les 4000 "a lot of mutual respect and solidarity in the daily life of the *cité*". In addition, Lepoutre (1997/2001, p. 80) claims that in La Courneuve, "friendships cross cultural barriers quite easily".
12. The appropriation of space and the territorialisation of the urban ecology of *banlieues* by youth have been associated with riots since the 1980s (Beaud and Pialoux, 2003, p. 341; Sayad, 1999, p. 324).
13. "An orthodoxy, a right, correct, dominant vision which has more often than not been imposed through struggles against competing visions" (Bourdieu, 1998, p. 56).
14. See the work of J. Beuys and interview with Monte at <http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2Ql8m4kW3G0>.

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